

What else to watch: *Battleship Potemkin* (1925, pp.28–29) ■ *Kapò* (1960) ■ *All the President's Men* (1976) ■ *Reds* (1981) ■ *Waltz with Bashir* (2008) ■ *Zero Dark Thirty* (2012)

“Give us your **bombers**, and you can have our **baskets**.”

Ben M'Hidi / The Battle of Algiers

The cost of terror

In its depiction of the horrors of conflict, *The Battle of Algiers* raises questions about right and wrong in war that are still relevant today. Pontecorvo portrays both sides very evenhandedly. The Algerian independence fighters, the FLN (National Liberation Front), lack the means or manpower to confront the occupying French military police in direct battle, so instead they resort to guerrilla warfare and terrorism. They employ children as messengers and have devout Muslim women Westernize their appearance in order to gain access to the European quarter. Their targets are not military, but rather civilian areas such as cafés and airports that are frequented by Europeans.

The sequence with the women is particularly telling as to the cost of the fight, as we watch while they cut off their hair, rid themselves of

their hijabs and remove any trace of their cultural and religious identity for the greater good as they would see it. They kill random Europeans, upon whose faces the camera dwells before the blasts, but there is no triumphalism from the women—in their eyes, they are committing a necessary evil.

The French military make their own compromises with morality, as they resort to violent interrogation and torture in order to obtain the information required to bring the FLN down. The movie begins

and ends with an Algerian man, tortured beyond comprehension, dressed humiliatingly in a French military uniform. Colonel Mathieu, the ranking officer in charge of bringing down the resistance movement, chastises one of the soldiers when they mock him for his appearance. This moment mirrors the later bombing, where Mathieu indicates that something of themselves—their pride, their moral high ground—has been given up in pursuit of victory. The movie views both sides' losses with »

Ali (Brahim Hadjadj, right) is recruited to the FLN by Djafar (Yacef Saadi, second left). Saadi fought with the FLN, and the character Djafar was partly based on Saadi himself.



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The Battle of Algiers is a training film for urban guerrillas.

Jimmy Breslin

New York Daily News, 1968

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